Portrait of a Bulimic

By Ally Sheedy

INTRODUCTION

Ally Sheedy, a member of the Brat Pack, who you may remember from The Breakfast Club and Saint Elmo's Fire, was a precocious child. She didn't start off wanting to be an actress, however; her first love was dance. She began studying with the American Ballet Theatre when she was 6, and performed professionally with the company well into her adolescence. In high school, she bridged the gap into acting when she began to do commercials and also when she spiraled down into the depths of bulimia – a potentially deadly disorder in which one binges and purges in a desperate attempt to be thin. According to the U.S. National Eating Disorders Association, approximately 4.7 million females and 1.5 million males suffer from bulimia.

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She lay on the heavy crocheted bedspread
looking at
her distended stomach.

I have done it again, she thinks.

She rolls to her side feeling
the bloat

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the skin
stretched so tightly
over her abdomen she fears
it will rupture.

A beached pink whale.

She can't move
can't think
can't speak

a whole box of chocolate

Piece after
gooey
gummy
rich
piece
stuffed into
my mouth

faster and faster and faster until
I can't taste
or chew
or stop
only endlessly repeat
hand to mouth

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hand to mouth
hand to mouth

Chocolate from my employers
I am a dancer she thinks-then laughs-and cries
and tries
to lean over the side of the bed and vomit
all her insides out.

If they could see me now, she thinks
They'd wonder why they ever thought of
hiring me.
They'd certainly want their chocolate back.
In its original condition.

She lies back on the pillows and closes her eyes.
She sees herself as the Rose
dancing in the musical garden
promoting feminine deodorant.

What good fortune
a windfall
landing this
commercial.

A dancing rose
Fasting for three days

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Starving for two weeks

So high
so empty
so alive.

How did I lose it?

She feels for weight under her chin
around her hipbones
inside her thighs.

She feels the fat cells accumulating
senses them growing in big globs
all over her body.

She can't move.

It was just yesterday . . .
she spent the night twirling in
sparkling pink sequins and a tight-waisted gauze skirt.

Such fine bones, said the director.
Such a tiny waist.
She nods, glows, dances up a storm
High on caffeine and saccharine and her own slight
self.

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3 A.M. --
Dizzy with exhaustion, reeling with success, taking off her
makeup.
I did it!
I am a dancer -- I look like one, act like one –
I have won!
No one has guessed a single solitary thing about me.
The prized pink dress hangs limply on its hanger.

She is in her underwear.
Dusty mirror.
tired sweat-streaked weak
sunken stomach
ribs
thin arms.
I did it, she says. There is no joy, only tenuous relief.

Behind the cold cream
half-hidden
half-eaten
an old package of Hostess powdered donuts.

a hand frozen in mid-air.
No, she says. No.
a small panic moving in her stomach
No.

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Squelching stuffing stop crying
hunger in my body -- dance clothes into my gym bag
a silent ongoing chant: you can't you mustn't you are not allowed

Good-bye, dressing room
Good-bye, commercial
Good-bye, rose dancer
and pink dress that isn't hers
that she'll never wear again.

Tomorrow I won't be pretty, pink, and fine-boned.
Tomorrow **I'll** just be myself
smoking, auditioning again, and in a black leotard.
I can't get those steps
always off the beat
never on top of anything.
endlessly tired -- falling short of the mark –
isn't that another definition of sin?
dieting and dieting and dieting

she pinches her body and sees it fat
sees it ugly wide and clumsy
it never changes no matter what she does
desperately does

Then today she lost it.

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Walked into a waiting room filled with glowing girls.
She was sure they had looked at her funny.
You are nothing, said their eyes.
You are a stick of wood, a mannequin, nothing.
I am transparent, she realized. I have yet to appear.
Yet to be recognized and gladly welcomed.

At the doorstep of her cold dark apartment
A box of chocolate lay waiting.
Thank you, said the note.
I am Alice in Wonderland.
One side makes you smaller and the other makes you tall.
Eat me, said the note.

Oh, please -- just one -- oh, please . . .
They sent it to ***me***!
Tearing through it, eating up the thought, the sweat,
and leotards
glowing girls and sparkling pink dresses
but alive finally
madly greedily terribly ***ALIVE***.
Eating everything in the world and squashing and ***getting***
it
grabbing it stuffing it in and down
I hate you, she said.
I'll kill you, she said with each exhilarating sinful and
angry chocolate bite.

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Now she lies on the bed.
Sick and once more passing slowly into oblivion.
Oh, how I hate you.

I close my eyes.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
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